

The Silent Revolution

For most of recorded history, reading was something you did out loud. Books were performed rather than consumed, and a library was a noisy place.

The change, when it came, was remarked upon as a curiosity. In the **Confessions**

Augustine records his astonishment at finding Ambrose, the bishop of Milan, reading without moving his lips. His eyes scanned the page and his heart sought out the meaning, but his voice and tongue were still.

What Augustine saw

Scholars have argued ever since about what exactly Augustine found so strange. The simplest reading is also the most startling: that silent reading was rare enough in the fourth century to stop a visitor in the doorway.

- Dr. Smith argues the practice was commoner than Augustine let on.
- Others point to the [manuscript evidence](https://example.com/ms), which is thin.
- The fare for a scribe was \$3.50 a day, e.g. roughly a labourer's wage.

```
```js
// This code block should not be read aloud.
const x = 1
```
```

Whatever the truth of it, the habit we now treat as ordinary was once the exception.